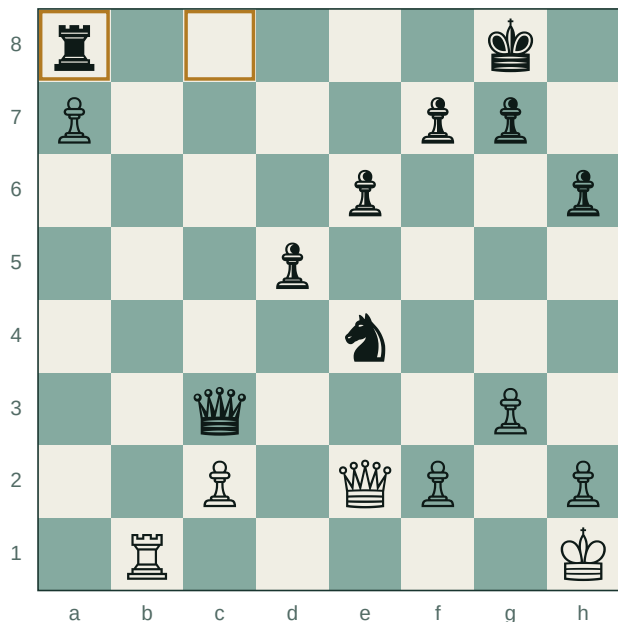


Promotion combinations: White, move 25

Promotion combinations

White to move



Previous move: 24...Ra8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

25. Rb8+ Rxb8 26. axb8=Q+

25.Rb8+ Check restricts Black to 3 legal replies here. From b8 it attacks king on g8 and rook on a8. Recorded reply: **25...Rxb8**.

26.axb8=Q+ Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. The pawn becomes a queen. The move also takes the rook on b8.

At the end, nominal material is White 22 / Black 17 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +8. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +8:** the balance goes from -3 to +5. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Always inspect stalemate and underpromotion resources. A queen is usually strongest, but the exact position determines the choice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An advanced pawn can turn a tactical sequence into a new queen or another useful piece. Promotion may occur with capture or check, and the choice of piece can change the outcome.

HOW TO LOOK

Calculate the pawn's route, the safety of the promotion square, and whether the new piece can survive or give a decisive check.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: rook on a8. Check for tactical protection.